united Afghanistan that was attracted to the vision of non-alignment globally, and wanted to balance Pakistan regionally (Afghanistan had opposed the creation of Pakistan at the UN in 1947) was, by definition, friendly. For the first three decades, till late 1970s, this bilateral dynamic remained largely intact despite its highs and lows. But then came Assadullah Sarwari and his comrades (see prologue), and things began to change. To India's dismay, developing and sustaining friendships in a polarised polity and a fractured state was not just difficult but also counterproductive. Because, under tough circumstances, Afghan friends, often desperate and wanting, would seek support that New Delhi may or may not be able, or willing, to offer.

While most requests may be legitimate, others may not be acceptable to the international community, and may also undermine ideals of democracy, secularism, equality, sovereignty, and, at times, even basic human rights (for example, in the case of Sarwari where India adopted unduly strong measures in favour of Najibullah). If India fails to provide such unconditional support, then not only its identity as a regional power, but even as a friend, comes under critical scrutiny in Kabul. Experts, thus, argue that Afghanistan is a 'litmus test for India's rise as a South Asian power with global potential'.[18] New Delhi's success or failure in managing its relations with and protecting its interests in Afghanistan provides an indication of its national strength. By highlighting the interplay of the three causal factors—balancing between Afghanistan and Pakistan, international political environment, and domestic Afghan politics—and its influence on India's Afghanistan policy, this book shows that India's presence in Afghanistan since the Soviet invasion is not just a test of national strength but also an indicator of how the world's largest democracy views itself and its place in a changing world order.

## *Note on theory*

Though scant in its use of theory, this book uses the Advocacy Coalition Framework (ACF) to conceptualise the terms 'partisans' and 'conciliators'. A leading theory of public policy processes, the ACF's emphasis on policy change, learning, and coalition behavior helps in doing this. At the macro-level the